

Unhelpful Thinking Styles

The way that we think affects how we feel. When a person experiences uncomfortable feelings (eg., low mood, anxiety), it's often because of negative thoughts that pop up automatically. These thoughts often follow patterns called "unhelpful thinking styles". When someone regularly engages in these thinking patterns, it can often cause a great deal of emotional distress.

This information sheet describes a number of "unhelpful thinking styles". As you read them, see whether you notice any thinking patterns and styles that you use frequently.

Mental Filter

This thinking style is like having tunnel vision—you focus on one part of a situation and ignore the rest. Often, this means paying attention only to the negative aspects and forgetting the positive, so the whole picture feels shaped by a single negative detail
E.g., Lisa struggled to enjoy the outing as all she could think about was her bloated stomach.

Jumping to Conclusions

This type of thinking involves drawing conclusions without considering all the evidence.

Mind reading: We jump to conclusions when we assume that we know what someone else is thinking.

E.g., If anyone sees me eating a doughnut they'll think I am fat and lazy.

Emotional Reasoning: This thinking style involves basing your view of situations or yourself on the way you are feeling.

E.g., I know that I've gained weight because of how I'm feeling.

Predictive thinking: We also jump to conclusions when we make predictions about what is going to happen in the future (predictive thinking).

E.g., If I eat 3 meals and 3 snacks a day my weight will never stop going up.



Personalisation

This involves blaming yourself for things that go wrong or could go wrong, even when you may only be partly responsible or not responsible at all. It often involves taking full responsibility for the occurrence of external events that you couldn't control.

E.g., It is all my fault that I have an eating disorder.

Labelling

This thinking style involves making sweeping judgments about yourself or others based on one specific behaviour or situation. You ignore other evidence that doesn't fit the label.

E.g., I'm weak because I can't stop bingeing.

Catastrophising

Catastrophising occurs when we "blow things out of proportion", or view a situation as terrible, awful, dreadful, and horrible, even though the problem itself is quite small.

E.g., If I gain weight, nobody will ever be attracted to me ever again.

Black and White Thinking

This thinking style involves seeing only one extreme or the other. It involves thinking that events and things can only be viewed as either wrong or right, good or bad, with no in-between.

E.g., Now that I've eaten one biscuit, I may as well eat all of them.

Shoulding and Musting

Sometimes by saying "I should..." or "I must..." you can put unreasonable demands or pressure on yourself and others. While these statements are not always unhelpful (e.g., "I should not steal"), they can sometimes create unrealistic expectations and lead to guilt or frustration.

E.g., I must never eat carbohydrates.



Overgeneralisation

When we overgeneralise, we take one instance in the past or present, and impose it on all current or future situations. If we say "You always..." or "Everyone...", or "I never..." then we are probably overgeneralising.

E.g., Everything in my life is perfect when my body is in peak condition.

Disqualifying the Positives

In this thinking style, you minimise your personal positive attributes and achievements. It's as though you're explaining away your own positive characteristics or achievements as though they're not important.

E.g., I know that I've made some improvements to my eating, but they're too little too late.

For more information on challenging unhelpful thinking styles, see CCI's thought diary handouts on our [website](http://www.cci.health.wa.gov.au).